

Volatile meets Non volatile

Researchers have developed a device that called dual floating gate FET, that can act as both volatile and non volatile memory

Hair on auction

When Britney Spears shaved all of her hair off in a Los Angeles salon in February 2007, her hair got listed on eBay for 1 million USD and saw some furious bidding



HomeShop18 is relatively new player

and lot of money will be generated.

In an ideal situation, the online space should offer an advantage to a new entrant, as compared to a traditional shop. This is because in online retail the shopping area is a 10-14 inch computer screen or the even smaller Tablet or mobile screen. You don't have to spend big bucks in acquiring prime real estate in centre of the city.

Online space is the ultimate level playing field, where any retailer can have an easy access to the prime real estate, which is the screen on customer's laptop or mobile. But any level playing field can yield results only when there are companies that are ready to make really large investments, which are backed by right kind of strategies. Merely blaming the deeply entrenched habits of Indian consumers won't do; our online retailers certainly need to evolve new ways of marketing their wares. You can't run a corner grocery shop without a right strategy; for selling online you surely need a truly out of the box thinking.

Wooing the Indian customer

The holiday season in USA sees large amount of goods being sold from e-commerce sites and this is primarily due to the massive discounts being offered. There are hardly any instances Indian consumers being offered that kind of massive discounts. Whether shopping in real world or in virtual, customers love discounts and sales. It is a well-known fact that Indian women don't like to miss any sale. The online retailers need to have right kind of alliances with manufacturers and producers so that they can sell different items at really cheap price on their websites. But in many cases, the Indian online stores tend to price their products higher than

in the real world. Clearly the intention is to accommodate back-end and logistics costs within the margin. This is a sure recipe for driving away the customer.

Then there is the issue of making a payment for goods purchased online. How many times have we heard people say, "Oh I don't mind buying online, but only reason I don't do that is because I don't wish to disclose credit card details to online vendors." Even though India is touted as a software superpower, majority of its citizens are insecure about using credit and debit cards to buy online. Our online retailers could certainly pitch in by doing all they can to make people feel safe when they place an order. The sites should remind customers that they are ordering through a secure server. Customers also need to be explicitly told that the website will not pass on their email addresses to any third party, and all the personal details will be kept confidential. In western countries many customers use systems such as PayPal to make payments. In India too, banks and online retailers could come together to create a system like PayPal so that customers can make a purchase without having to use his credit or debit card. Some outlets like Flipkart are letting the customers pay by cash at the time of delivery. This is a good idea.

The quality of service is also important. If you take many days to deliver an item after an order has been placed, then it is highly likely that the customer might lose all enthusiasm for buying online in future. Also, many online retailers in India are having high costs of delivery. This makes the deal uneconomical for the customer, as they can get the product cheaper in the neighbourhood markets. It is possible

that the product might be damaged when it reaches the customer, or there might be some other problem, in such cases the issue has to be resolved quickly. There should be some sort of money back guarantee. More than anything else, the online retailers have to learn to be pushy in selling their products like any persistent salesman at a shop. Indians also tend to buy when they see any urgency to do so. Once again we come back to the marketing strategy of having bumper limited period sales.

With broadband spreading at a scorching pace, there is no doubt that online retail enjoys a rosy future in India. According to some analysts, by 2015 India could have largest number of Internet users, and entrepreneurs have

“Online buying is saving me time and money. Before buying any book, I can compare the rates from different websites and buy from where the prices are lowest. I won't think of buying a new dress online, or even a new electronic device”

Smiriti Khanna, College Student

to begin now to tap the amazing financial power of this large base of potential customers. The huge number of smartphone users could certainly turn out to a worthy target, as they are connected to the Internet round the clock. Surendra Bhatia travels often for his job in banking industry, and he has used his mobile to shop from

retail outlets in India few times. He says, "It is quite normal for me to be stuck at airports while waiting for my flight, so it's more convenient for me to use the time to do the shopping through my mobile." The bottom line is that many more Indians can warm up to online retailers if they can have better incentives. ■



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